

*All the images will
disappear...until
I look at them*



→ Gruppo Storico Novese, Novi and the Novesi 2: un secolo di storia locale ripercorso con le memorie fotografiche (sponsored by the Province of Modena, Novi di Modena 2007) photo on p. 203.

*"Like sexual desire, memory never stops. It pairs the dead with the living, real with imaginary beings, dreams with history."*¹

It is a black and white photo, published in a volume titled *"Novi e i Novesi 2: un secolo di storia locale ripercorso con le memorie fotografiche"* [Novi and the Novesi 2: A century of local history retraced with photographic memories]² of a small town in the countryside of north Italy. Selected from among many others, mostly intended for family distribution, it is now an archival document.

The shot captures a young man leaning back against the open door of a truck, legs crossed, torso in three-quarter-view, gesturing towards some manual action: Is he tying something? Closing or packing something? It is impossible for me to read the image any further, because that area of the image fades into the shadow as it is disturbed by the film grain. He doesn't look up, so the camera lens doesn't capture his gaze, his face is bowed as he is absorbed in some momentary task. The man and his truck are suspended in an absence of landscape, which would also seem to suggest an absence of time, they float in an overexposed horizon. A detail interrupts my reading of the image and takes my place, leaving me afflicted with confronting emotions. ()

On the side, between the sun-faded wooden planks that cover the truck, in capital letters I read: AUTOCOLONNA ROVATTI. Autocolonna means convoy, caravan. Rovatti is the surname of my grandfather, my mother and myself. Each time I look at the image, I'm startled by this connection. I freeze in the moment of recognition, there is a line that joined him to me but our eyes will never meet. This awareness makes me restless, anxious: no matter how hard I try, I can't find a single revealing detail in his face. No hidden message, no expression, no answers to my questions, just a gaze that relentlessly escapes mine.

Nonetheless I wonder if the point is instead to notice the physical sensations that this image and its story evoke in me, to tend to this feeling, to offer it a particular kind of listening. Although the image of this man is disembodied for me, without any voice, smell or gesture, after all, I never knew him and was not given any family anecdotes or mythologies about him, it seems to me that the image is filled with a *"dizzying proximity between things, bodies, and memories, which makes the very process of remembering an essentially political act, an act that engages the physical and spatial dimension, a recollection."*²

I borrow this way of questioning images, of engaging with them, from the artist and researcher Onyeka Igwe. As a Black woman, Igwe enters the archive using her body as a primary sensory device, capturing and holding onto every bodily flare and tremor information carried by senses beyond sight, knowledge that resides elsewhere. This approach, known as *critical proximity*³, is one that

1 Annie Ernaux, *The Years* (Seven Stories Press 2017), 10.

2 My own translation from Giulia Grechi e Viviana Gravano, *Presente imperfetto. Eredità coloniali e immaginari razziali contemporanei* (Milano: Mimesis 2016), 42.

3 The term alludes to critical distance, a concept rooted in Western positivist empiricism. In critical proximity, the word "critical" seeks to elevate historically marginalized ways of knowing, positioning them alongside dominant knowledge systems within the same framework of legitimacy and value.

Igwe, in turn, borrows from Bruno Latour⁴ in an imagined conversation with Donna Haraway about situated knowledge and feminist objectivity.

Critical proximity, she explains, is about the living breathing presence of the body extending beyond the archive, as a point of departure for speaking *“to the ethical dilemma of looking for oneself in colonial moving images or looking, as Frantz Fanon (1967, p. 109) describes, at ‘being through others.’”*⁵ But not all bodies carry the same weight, and mine, in relation to this photo, doesn’t exude the same political act as Igwe’s does in her video works.

How, then, can I use this same methodology to reflect on my own positioning?

The photographic critic Susan Sontag in the context of The Saigon Execution and responding to a photograph taken by Eddie Adams on February 1, 1968, during the Tet Offensive wrote *“one can gaze at those faces for a long time without being able to understand the mystery and indecency of the spectacle we are called to witness.”*⁶ The American photojournalist captures Nguyen Ngoc Loan, the then-head of the National Police of the Republic of Vietnam, at the moment when he summarily executes the Vietcong officer Nguyen Van Lém on the streets of Saigon. Yet these same words seem equally applicable to me when encountering all those faces of men and women in colonial archives: a body of knowledge made of postcards, cabinet cards, souvenir images of the human zoos of the Universal Expos or portraits of colonized people taken in recently acquired territories; usually filed with little information about their provenance. One of the first operations carried out by colonial domination was in fact that of classification, meaning a violent process of data acquisition. The Cuban-American artist and curator Coco Fusco writes:

*“postcards and stereoscopic photographs titillated them [white audiences] with intimations of sexual attraction between white woman and black or Native American men; images of costumed microcephalics, masquerading as examples of “backward” races, were grotesque parodies of positivist reasoning.”*⁷

As Fusco asserts while analyzing the relationship between “race” and photography in defining identity throughout Europe from the mid-nineteenth century to the mid-twentieth century, the photographic portrait became a mass device of individualization for the imperialist and industrial bourgeoisie. Through this device, white European and American citizens not only self-

4 Bruno Latour, Critical distance or critical proximity? (Written for a book in homage of Donna Haraway but then rejected by the editor 2005)

5 Onyeka Igwe, “Being close to, with or amongst” in Feminist Review, no 125, issue 1 (2020) <https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/10.1177/0141778920918152> (accessed 6 March 2025).

6 Susan Sontag, Regarding the Pain of Others (Picador 2004), 74.

7 Coco Fusco, Only skin deep : changing visions of the American self (New York : International Center of Photography in association with Harry N. Abrams, Inc., Publishers 2003), 21.

represented, but also identified who they were different from.

The images of these Others and of the entire world were miniaturized and objectified through the photographic device, and then collected, appropriated, owned. In the presence of these women and men, these Others, the only role that seems granted is compassion, or outrage towards the perpetrators. But compassion is an unstable and detached emotion; it legitimizes us to not consider ourselves complicit. Perhaps, by forcing myself to confront certain images of violence, I realize that they are inseparable from me: I'm not the potential Vietcong, I'm the potential South Vietnamese general. ()

I return to the conflicting experience of looking at my starting image, whose caption will better contextualize my ethical dilemma of searching for myself in it:

*"Truck with the stamp Rovatti Convoy. After the conquest of Ethiopia in 1936, several people from Novi went and searched for a brighter future in the new land of the sun. Some left to work with Italian companies, others organized themselves by setting up small companies able to offer services to the Italian companies themselves, as in the case of the Rovatti group."*⁸

On the phone, when interrogated on our genealogy my mom's voice tells me about the epiphany she had during her university years, the year she was preparing a five-year thesis as a history student on the massacre at Sant'Anna di Stazzema, a German war crime committed in a hill village in Tuscany, Italy 1944 (ironically, a study on silences and forgetfulness). It was in the same year, a seemingly irrelevant detail that nonetheless resonates within me, that I was conceived. She told me:

*"At a certain point, while working on Sant'Anna di Stazzema and on the evacuations, the partisans, and the advance of the front, it becomes increasingly clear to me that a family fleeing north in 1944 could not be partisans. They were going in the wrong direction!"*⁹

A Pandora's box that leads her, through documents and archival folders, to revisit a long-silenced family history, repressed because it was *"unresolved, unmanageable, burdened with its load of conflicting emotions"*¹⁰.

8 My own translation from Gruppo Storico Novese, Novi and the Novesi 2: un secolo di storia locale ripercorso con le memorie fotografiche (sponsored by the Province of Modena, Novi di Modena 2007) photo on p. 203.

9 Transcript of a phone conversation with my mother, 21 June 2023.

10 My own translation from Giulia Grechi e Viviana Gravano, *Presente imperfetto. Eredità coloniali e immaginari razziali contemporanei* (Milano: Mimesis 2016), 25.

My mother continued:

“Once this thread is pulled, it emerges that my grandfather Ugo came from a background of local militancy, including leadership: from the March on Rome to a role in the Republican Fascist executive in Modena under the RSI, where he was responsible for the Provincial Food Section, SEPRAL (which dealt with food rationing and the distribution of ration cards), all the way to the colonial venture of the Rovatti/Bufarini Guidi brick factory in Addis Abeba, Ethiopia. Meanwhile, his eldest son, Uncle M., enlisted voluntarily at seventeen to fight in the Balkans among the ranks of the Blackshirts between 1942 and ’43. A picture emerges of a family of economic profiteers, early fascists, albeit of a secondary role. I also realize a distinctly right-leaning family tendency in the immediate post-war period. I discover that the beloved Aunt E. voted for the MSI (Italian Social Movement) for a long time. I understand that I have reached the heart of something my father already knows, and in questioning him, I am twisting the knife in an open, still-living wound.”¹¹

The family my mother speaks of is her father’s, the youngest of five siblings, son of the man in the photo. Before this very conversation I’ve been told uncountable times, with a certain degree of complacency in self-representation, the history of the side of the family that actively participated in the resistance, not once was a fascist affiliation ever mentioned. How is it possible that Ugo Rovatti’s name was erased from family narratives around a festive table, forgotten in the dusty corners of a state archive, until my mother’s accidental discovery? And why, to some extent, had my mother also chosen to pass down the gaps and silences? ()

She doesn’t elude my questions but (perhaps with a degree of intentionality) refrains from offering an emotional response: the lack of sufficient records or historical evidence makes proper research impossible, leaving Ugo Rovatti’s eight years in Ethiopia shrouded in uncertainty. Yet, I can’t help but consider what is gained for our sense of identity through the histories that remains untold or erased. To delve deeper into the acts of forgetting in my lineage I will examine what it meant for my grandfather, a socially active and progressive man for his time, to exhume the ghosts of a family from which he had ideologically distanced himself.

The Rovatti family, long after Ugo’s so-called glorious colonial exploits had ended in economic failure, left Novi in 1944 following an attempted partisan raid. This information emerges from a report by the *65th Garibaldi*

*Assault Brigade*¹², and it alone should make clear the family's prominent role in the town's fascist militancy. In Novi di Modena, the Rovatti left everything behind: their home, their family business (a small pharmacy), and, most of all, their social status. They fled from a near-certain death, abandoning the small-town fascist bourgeoisie they had been part of. They arrived in Milan penniless, and, like half of Italy's population in those years, they endured hunger.

My grandfather was four years old. He merely remembers, or perhaps only recounts, the roar of bombings during the journey. In postwar Milan, they slowly rebuilt their lives under the shadow of an unspoken stain and disgrace.

Of the four sons, my grandfather was the only one to defy his father's orders, choosing to attend a humanities-focused high school instead of enrolling in accounting. Later, he studied Philosophy at university, became a teaching assistant, and eventually secured a faculty position at the same institution. In 1976, he took over as editor of *Aut Aut*, a philosophy journal. During those years, he was politically active, writing and thinking while moving through bourgeois lounges of the Milan *intelligenza*, even flirting with the most extreme fringes of extra parliamentary politics, to the point of risking accusations of terrorism.

I don't know what kind of relationship he kept with his brothers and parents; he never spoke of them. The only one he ever mentioned was Aunt E., ten years older than him, who had practically raised him like a mother. Even now, when he speaks of her, his voice trembles with tenderness. And yet, Aunt E. voted proudly for right wing racist parties until the very end of her life. How does one exist within such contradictions? How does one distance oneself from a legacy deemed cumbersome or unacceptable, without silences, removals, sharp ruptures between generations, or rather compromises and adaptations?

*"Haraway teaches
fleshy inheritance is what we are made of,
who we have touched, and retouched,
who has touched and retouched us,
human and not,
over the course of our lives
and deaths.*

*Barad says (Barad 2014, p. 81), "the past is always open":
Facing history is
"to acknowledge and be responsive [. . .] to open oneself up"
(Barad 2010, p. 264 in Barad 2014, p. 183)
to our situated stories
to speak with our material ghosts;"*¹³

¹² From archival document, military service record of 65a Brigata d'Assalto Garibaldi "Walter Tabacchi", 12 October 1944.

¹³ Rebecca Ream, "Composting Layers of Christchurch History" in *Genealogy*, no 5, Issue 3 (2021), <https://doi.org/10.3390/genealogy5030074> (accessed 6 March 2025).

In her situated tale *Composting Layers of Christchurch History*, independent researcher Rebecca Ream confronts her own heritage as a descendant of colonial settlers in New Zealand. She does so through a fragmented, layered poem that engages with critical autoethnography methodologies. Ream reinterprets Donna Haraway's concept of composting to suggest that nothing precedes relation, and that relation inherently involves encounters with muddles. Such collisions are at times violent and certainly non-innocent but find fertility in their contingency and capabilities of response.¹⁴

From her words, I learn that there is no escaping our troubled past, only the challenge of questioning our assumptions about identity, of facing what we inherit in the flesh. I now realize that I have spent more time clarifying, justifying, and reassuring, emphasizing the ethical and ideological goodness of my origins: "after all, my grandfather was a socialist!" rather than dwelling on what truly unsettles me. The discovery that, by blood, I am tied to colonialism.

The unspoken fear that I might carry, inscribed in my very being, the capacity for violence. Partly, I do this to restore complexity, nuance, and contradiction. But also, I do it to make my family history feel less uncomfortable, less unbearable. I should try to resist this ever-present impulse toward apology by practicing *critical proximity*, by rejecting Western fantasies of purity and transcendence in an attempt of embodying responsibility.



I begin with the picture of my great-grandfather in search of this perspective, in search of the ways in which my body respond to it, to twisting the knife in this open, still living wound, seeking discomfort, an unsettling space, a process of reckoning with certain unclear recesses.

The same diaristic, episodic, and intimate images "*images from dreams in which the dead parents come back to life, and you walk down unidentifiable roads*"¹⁵ serve as witnesses to a painful past, over which the collective voice of history is layered in a nonlinear way. It is about trying to put together the scattered pieces of my cultural identity, not innocently or guiltily, but staying stuck in the colonial mud, the muddle of who we are.¹⁶

¹⁴ Ibidem.

¹⁵ Annie Ernaux, *Thé Years* (Seven Stories Press 2017), 10.

¹⁶ Rebecca Ream, "Composting Layers of Christchurch History" in *Genealogy*, no 5, Issue 3 (2021), <https://doi.org/10.3390/genealogy5030074> (accessed 6 March 2025).



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